Tel: Decypher.
Sir T. Wade
D 2 Oct 1874.
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No 201

Peking
2nd Oct. 1874.

My Lord,

My Despatch No 198 of the 16th Septr. will have informed your Lordship of my opinion of the present situation, and of the danger by which this Government is threatened at home and abroad.

At home, things are so far better that the Prince of Kung has resumed his place as chief

The Earl of Derby
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chief of the Government certainly without any loss in the judgment of some persons, with an increase, of power. The news from the provinces is at the same time rather — reassuring than otherwise.

The misunderstanding with Japan, on the other hand, appears as far as Ever, if not farther, from settlement. I received, on the 24th September, a note from Sir Charles Shadwell, then at Nagasaki,

dated the 15th to the effect that Sir Harry Parkes, as he had just learned by telegram, thought so ill of the chances of peace as to have decided on abandoning his intended tour, and had detained the man of war in which he was about to embark, at Yokohama. I wrote next morning to the High Commissioner Okubo to request an interview with him the same afternoon. The

Commissioner was unable to receive me until the following day, and I then informed him of the note that I had received from the Admiral, and, apologising for the directness with which I felt it my duty to put questions about matters immediately concerning Japan, I asked if, since we last spoke together upon the subject, a solution of the difficulty between China and Japan had become

become more probable. The Commissioner said that since his arrival here he had been in constant communication with the Tsung-li Yamên, and that he hoped in a few conferences more the point at issue might be disposed of.

I ventured to ask if I might be informed exactly of the nature of the particular difficulty to be settled. The Commissioner's reply to his interpreter occupied several minutes, but the sum of it, then communicated to me, was that it was of so complicated a nature that it would take a long time to explain. The Commissioner's instructions were to maintain peace and he had hopes that a few conferences more would settle the question.

I think I understood him, however, to state that the precise point to be disposed of had not yet been

been reached in discussion. At any rate, in reply to my next direct question, namely, whether if China were to accede to certain conditions the troops of Japan would withdraw from Formosa, the Commissioner answered that under certain — conditions they would, but that these conditions were not either set before the Chinese.

I repeated that my only excuse for troubling the Commissioner with such inquiries was the magnitude of

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of our interests in China. I had told the Chinese from the first, whenever the question had come up, that although I and others had always regarded Formosa as part of the Chinese Empire, I did not feel free to declare that that part of the island occupied by the Aborigines, was not, as the Japanese contend, independent of China, until I had heard the arguments advanced by Japan upon the other side, into the question of territorial rights. Therefore, I was not presuming

to

to enter. At the same time the postponement of a decision of whatever might be the question undecided between the two Governments affected British interests nearly; the possibility of a rupture necessarily — made me anxious on behalf of those interests; so much so that I had already telegraphed to Her Majesty's Government to recommend that the squadron protecting those interests should at once be reinforced. This state

of

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of uncertainty and disquiet would, I foresaw, endure so long as the Japanese continued to occupy Formosa. If therefore, Japan were prepared to offer conditions to China, I should be very willing, if the conditions appeared to me reasonable, to do my best to induce the Chinese to accept them.

The Commissioner thanked me for my friendly offer of good offices. He hoped however, in a very few

conferences more to see his way, and he would then have the pleasure of communicating with me.

All this with remarkable good humour and urbanity, though with as much embarrassment as might be expected in a man who was being pressed hard for an answer that it did not suit him to give.

Our conference had closed when, perhaps to prevent its resumption, the Commissioner produced a bottle of champagne, and having asked him to dine with me, I took my leave.

I had sent Mr. Mayers to the Yamên on the 25th to inform the Ministers of the news received through Sir Charles Shadwell; but they made little of it. Indeed they sent me so curt an answer from the Prince of Kung to the last message conveyed from me through their Excellencies to His Highness, that I came to the conclusion that they had not only no faith in

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the disinterestedness of my advice, but believed me to be working in the interest of Japan.

This produced a long note from me to the Prince in which I reviewed the situation and justified the counsels I had given, the offensiveness of which consisted in this, that China being utterly unprepared for war, being exposed to invasion at any point of the coast the moment war might be declared, and in peril of insurrection within, it behoved her, before all things to induce the Japanese to withdraw from Formosa, even were withdrawal to be purchased by payment of indemnity for war expenses. On the 25th a paper was handed by the Ministers to Mr Mayers, which, after reciting summarily what had passed at the last conference with myself, ended with a question from the Prince why, having once before condemned payment of indemnity, Mr Wade should now recommend it.

I at once returned their Memorandum to the Ministers and I addressed the Prince of Kung a long note in which I reviewed the situation and justified the counsel I had given from the first. I closed with an assurance of my extreme desire to see the crisis pass without resort to war, adding that if some other advisers should prove more fortunate than I had been, as none could be better pleased than myself.

This was acknowledged last evening in a very civil note from the Prince in which I am requested to receive the Ministers of the Yamên at the Legation tomorrow afternoon, there being various matters in my note which require further explanation, and questions put in it that are difficult to answer.

I shall here close this Despatch.

I have the honor to be,
My Lord,
with the highest respect,
Your Lordship's
Most obedient humble Servant
Thomas Francis Wade.

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1874
Peking October 2nd
Mr. Wade
No. 201

Recd 9ber 24

Ref. No. 198. China & Japan. Interview with Japanese Commissioner.

Approve proceedings
Dec 7/74

To the Queen
Mr Disraeli
Circulate

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Peking
2nd Oct 1874

My Lord,

The Ministers of the Yamen, as I have stated in the foregoing Despatch of this date, come to the Legation to talk of the Japanese affair, tomorrow. I expect little or nothing from the conference. They, with the Prince of Kung at their head, are for peace; possibly at any price; but there is, I am

he
arl of Derby
&c &c